This experience brought back memories of Ganesan, a dedicated party worker from Tamil Nadu who had lost his life in a tragic accident months earlier during the Yatra. He was hit by a speeding lorry that was trying to overtake the lorry in front of him. He died fighting for his life in the hospital. Samuvel, a young man, his fellow companion, who was hit along with him, survived with a minor head injury. Whenever the Congress party embarked on a march, Ganesan was a steadfast presence. He earned the affectionate moniker ‘Yatrai Ganesan’ due to his unwavering commitment to attending these marches. Carrying a bag brimming with photographs and certificates from the numerous marches he had participated in, Ganesan had found joy in showcasing them to every participant, his enthusiasm mirroring that of a child. Remarkably, he extended his camaraderie even to those who couldn’t comprehend Tamil, passionately explaining and making the experience relatable to everyone. Ganesan was a familiar face to all on the march, creating a sense of camaraderie that transcended language barriers. The poignant moment of laying a wreath on his lifeless body in his hometown left a lasting impact on everyone. His absence had left a void in the Yatra forever!

As the march from Haryana crossed the Delhi border in the morning, the challenges of managing security became glaringly apparent. The usual excitement of the crowd had peaked, making them all look possessed to meet and embrace Rahul. That, along with no proper security arrangements, made the situation look dire. Even the route for Rahul’s procession to the stage, where the national flag would be handed over, remained undecided until his arrival. The police force, tasked with handling such a vast crowd, displayed a lack of interest in security duties. As the crowd continued to swell, the Delhi Police eventually abandoned the responsibility, leaving the entire security burden to the CRPF. The CPRF mandate was solely Rahul Gandhi’s security, and they were not equipped to manage the surging tide of people. There were no safety rings, no ropes. The crowd pressed in around Rahul Gandhi, creating an even more potentially hazardous situation.

Despite the lack of proper control measures, the CRPF personnel remained vigilant, dedicating themselves to their duty with 200 per cent